



Merchant and his wife, 1590



"Sack! Sack! A sup of sack!" shouts a man selling wine

"Ink! Ink! Pen and ink!" cries a man selling quills and ink

"Trinkets and toys! Trinkets and toys!" calls the tinker

"Almanacs!" cries a man selling books of predictions

"Mack-mack-mackereel!" shouts a mackerel seller

SOUNDS OF THE CITY

London was full of street sellers shouting out special cries to attract customers. Men and women wandered the streets selling everything from vegetables, fish, wine, toys, and books, to quills and ink, fruit, brooms, pies, and second-hand clothes. They competed for business with the craftsmen and tradesmen working in the shops that lined the noisy, narrow streets.



BUILDING UP

Staple Inn, where wool was weighed and taxed in Shakespeare's day, is one of the few buildings still standing in London that the playwright would recognize. Land was expensive, so people built upward. The top floors of these towering buildings jutted outward over the street, creating more space inside, but blocking out light below.

MERCHANTS' MIGHT

The city was run by wealthy businessmen called merchants. The richest merchants served as officials, called aldermen, on a ruling council headed by the Lord Mayor. Trade was central to the prosperity of the city, and every craft and trade had its own controlling organization called a guild.

The Latin text along the top of the map describes London as "The most famous market in the entire world"

The bells of more than 100 churches rang out across the city



Shakespeare worshipped here, at St. Mary Overie's Church, later known as Southwark Cathedral

Set of 16th-century standard weights



Traitors' heads were displayed on poles on London Bridge to warn the public against committing treason

MEASURE FOR MEASURE

The guilds controlled trade using standard weights. They employed official measurers to check that members were not cheating their customers. Anyone caught selling short measures was locked in the stocks for punishment.